



Christopher You

PhD · Human-Centered Computing

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Summary

PhD in Human-Centered Computing with a research program at the intersection of applied AI systems, conversational agents, and human-AI collaboration in healthcare. First author of 8+ and co-author of 9+ peer-reviewed publications and across HCI and AI venues, with NIH-funded projects spanning psychiatric care, cancer clinical trials, and dissertation research on AI-mediated mental well-being. Experienced in mentoring undergraduate and graduate students to independent research and publication. Committed to advancing human-centered AI that is rigorously evaluated, broadly accessible, and designed to meaningfully improve real lives.

Education

Ph.D. in Human-Centered Computing

University of Florida

Advisor: Dr. Benjamin Lok

Dissertation: "A Change in Perspective: Exploring Interaction Paradigms in AI and Virtual Human Systems that Engage Users and Promote Mental Health"

Aug 2020 - May 2026

GPA: 3.8

M.S. in Computer Science

University of Florida

Advisor: Dr. Benjamin Lok

Aug 2020 - Dec 2022

GPA: 3.8

B.S. in Computer Science

University of Minnesota

Advisor: Dr. Evan Suma Rosenberg

Sep 2018 - May 2020

GPA: 3.8

Experience

Research Assistant

University of Florida

Aug 2020 - May 2026

- Broad impacts of research: (1) embodied agents to improve care for psychiatric patients (**NIH R34 Grant**), (2) AI clinical trial enrollment platform for cancer patients (**NIH R24/U01 Grant**), (3) AI patient simulations in university curriculum, and (4) conversational AI and agentic systems to support mental well-being.
- Designed **Build-a-Being Yourself**, a web-based conversational AI research platform enabling domain experts to rapidly author and deploy agent-based interventions at scale across multiple active studies.
- Developed and evaluated a multi-institutional **AI Clinical Trial Enrollment Platform**, conducting user studies with 1500+ patients and building evaluation pipelines analyzing model outputs, engagement metrics, and behavioral outcomes.
- Investigated human-AI collaboration through 10+ web-deployed user studies, integrating user-state modeling, retrieval-augmented generation, LLM fine-tuning, and VR technologies into experimental research protocols.
- Mentored undergraduate and graduate students in research methods, system development, and academic writing, directly advising 3 undergraduates to peer-reviewed publication.

Teaching Assistant

University of Florida

Jan 2024 - May 2024

- Designed coursework and projects for CEN4722: User Experience Design, including a semester-long capstone in which 25 student teams conducted user interviews with campus organizations and peers to identify pain points and prototype meaningful application solutions.

- Curated weekly readings to reinforce course objectives and develop critical thinking around human-centered design principles.
- Collaborated with faculty to plan lectures and course activities, held regular office hours, and provided feedback to support 100 students across all stages of the design process.

Research Assistant

May 2022 - Aug 2022

Davidson College

- Conducted in-depth research on embodiment and agency in avatars within VR and desktop environments, leading to two publications.
- Built IK-driven avatar systems to achieve high-fidelity user embodiment using consumer VR tracking.

Software Engineering Intern

May 2020 - Aug 2020

Amazon

- Architected knowledge graph-backed query system spanning Amazon Help Services and Alexa, enabling semantic search across large-scale service documentation.
- Designed and implemented full-stack SPARQL query interface, integrating NLP-driven entity resolution with a structured graph backend.
- Built frontend and API layer to expose graph query results to end users at production scale.

Research Assistant

Oct 2018 - May 2020

University of Minnesota

- Created novel redirection techniques for locomotion in VR, leading to two publications.
- Developed programming skills in C# using Unity to explore practical applications of VR systems.

Publications

Journal Proceedings

- [3] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Vilaro, M., Venkatakrishnan, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Maxim, A., Peng, X., Tamboli, D., & Lok, B. (2025). Alter egos alter engagement: Perspective-taking can improve disclosure quantity and depth to ai chatbots in promoting mental wellbeing. *Frontiers in Digital Health*, 7, 1655860
- [2] **You, C.**, Venkatakrishnan, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Han, Z., Lok, B., & Peck, T. (2024). A sense of urgency on the sense of agency: Challenges in evaluating agency and embodiment in virtual reality. *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics*
- [1] **You, C.**, Peck, T., Stuart, J., Gomes de Siqueira, A., & Lok, B. (2024). What my bias meant for my embodiment: An investigation on virtual embodiment in desktop-based virtual reality. *Frontiers in Virtual Reality*, 5, 1251564

Conference Proceedings

- [6] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Canales, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Vilaro, M., & Lok, B. (In preparation). Human-ai collaboration and user-state modeling promotes engagement in mental health conversations. *Proceedings of the 25th ACM conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work and Social Computing*, 1–8
- [5] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Venkatakrishnan, R., Maxim, A., Peng, X., Tamboli, D., Huang, Z., & Lok, B. (2026). Build-a-being yourself: A web-based system for authoring embodied conversational agents in healthcare research. *Proceedings of the 28th International Conference on Human-Computer Interaction*, 1–15
- [4] Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Venkatakrishnan, R., & Lok, B. (2025b). The impact of health literacy in a virtual agent intervention addressing barriers to cancer clinical trial participation. *Proceedings of the 13th International Conference on Human-Agent Interaction*, 76–86
- [3] Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Venkatakrishnan, R., & Lok, B. (2025a). Exploring the influence of multiple virtual agents for addressing barriers to cancer clinical trial participation. *Proceedings of the 25th ACM International Conference on Intelligent Virtual Agents*, 1–10

- [2] **You, C.**, Benda, B., Rosenberg, E. S., Ragan, E., Lok, B., & Thomas, J. (2022). Strafing gain: Redirecting users one diagonal step at a time. *2022 IEEE international symposium on mixed and augmented reality (ISMAR)*, 603–611
- [1] **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Maxim, A., Stuart, J., Cooks, E., & Lok, B. (2022). How does a virtual human earn your trust? guidelines to improve willingness to self-disclose to intelligent virtual agents. *Proceedings of the 22nd ACM International Conference on Intelligent Virtual Agents*, 1–8

Posters, Abstracts, & Demos

- [8] Kauer, T., Franco, C., Munroe, D., Flood-Grady, E., Gaillard, T., George, T., Lin, T., Lok, B., Tucker, C., Vilaro, M., Webb, F., Wilke, D., Wilson-Howard, D., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Serat, J., Buhr, M., Murphy, C., van Mossel, A., ... Krieger, J. (2025). Representation matters: The feasibility and impact of photo-realistic and social identity-matched virtual community health educators among black, hispanic, and rural adults. *Science of Community Outreach and Engagement Annual Conference*, 1
- [7] Huynh, L., **You, C.**, Mazorra, G., Black, E., Lok, B., & Blue, A. (2025). A patient chatbot to support interprofessional learning [Oral presentation]. *Collaborating Across Borders IX*, 1
- [6] Munroe, D., Kauer, T., Franco, C., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Ford, H., Lok, B., & Krieger, J. L. (2025). Connecting communities: Developing a provider portal to enhance cancer trial diversity. *Science of Communication Outreach and Engagement Annual Conference*, 1
- [5] Kauer, T., Franco, C., Lok, B., Tucker, C., Lin, T., Flood-Grady, E., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Wilson-Howard, D., Gaillard, T., Anton, S., & Krieger, J. (2025). Connecting older adults to clinical trials: Developing the alex clinical trial referral portal. *14th Annual Alliance Meeting for Healthy Aging Conference*, 1
- [4] Kauer, T., Franco, C., Munroe, D., Flood-Grady, E., Gaillard, T., Lin, T., Lok, B., Tucker, C., Wilson-Howard, D., Ghosh, R., **You, C.**, Serat, J., Buhr, M., Wynter, S., Anton, S., & Krieger, J. (2025). A strengths- and community-based approach to increasing medical research participation among black, hispanic, and white rural populations in florida [poster presentation]. *Mayo Clinic Transforming Community and Rural Healthcare 2025 Conference, Rochester, MN*, 1
- [3] Ghosh, R., Maxim, A., **You, C.**, & Lok, B. (2024). Real-time virtual human for promoting clinical trial education and recruitment. *2024 IEEE Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces Abstracts and Workshops (VRW)*, 1184–1185
- [2] Jurczyk, K., **You, C.**, Nourani, M., Gupta, M., Anthony, L., & Lok, B. (2021). Romadoro: Leveraging nudge techniques to encourage break-taking. *Adjunct Proceedings of the 34th Annual ACM Symposium on User Interface Software and Technology*, 66–69
- [1] **You, C.**, Suma Rosenberg, E., & Thomas, J. (2019). Strafing gain: A novel redirected walking technique. *Symposium on Spatial User Interaction*, 1–1

Undergraduate-Mentored Articles

Undergraduate journal publications authored by students whom I directly mentored on a weekly basis throughout the project and manuscript development.

- [2] Huynh, L., Blue, A., **You, C.**, Lok, B., Smith, G., Ghosh, R., & Venkatakrisnan, R. (2025). A feasibility study to assess virtual patients authenticity on building confidence in students' clinical decision-making. *UF Journal of Undergraduate Research*, 27
- [1] Smith, G., Huynh, L., **You, C.**, Ghosh, R., Venkatakrisnan, R., & Lok, B. (2025). Evaluating lip synchronization techniques in llm-based virtual humans for healthcare and computer science applications. *UF Journal of Undergraduate Research*, 27

Presentations and Invited Talks

Jan 2026	Newspaper Interview , When ChatGPT becomes a crisis helpline	<i>The Independent Alligator</i>
Mar 2025	Guest Talk , Embodied experiences to improve online virtual human mental health interventions	<i>Illusioneering Lab, UMN</i>
Oct 2024	Conference , A sense of urgency on the sense of agency: challenges in evaluating agency and embodiment in virtual reality.	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
Mar 2024	Consortium , Using the health belief model to tailor virtual humans for clinical trials	<i>IEEE VR</i>
Jun 2023	Guest Lecture , Strafing gain: Redirecting users one diagonal step at a time	<i>CEN4721 - HCI</i>
Oct 2022	Conference , Strafing gain: Redirecting users one diagonal step at a time	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
Sep 2022	Conference , How does a virtual human earn your trust? guidelines to improve willingness to self-disclose to intelligent virtual agents.	<i>ACM IVA</i>
Oct 2019	Poster , Strafing gain: A novel redirected walking technique	<i>ACM SUI</i>

Funding Received

2023 - 2026	Generation NEXT Fellowship , \$10,000/yr	<i>University of Florida</i>
2024 - 2025	L3Harris Graduate Scholarship , \$2,500	<i>University of Florida</i>
2021 - 2022	Olson-Mitchell STEM Translational Communications Project Award , \$5,000	<i>University of Florida</i>
2020 - 2026	Graduate School Preeminence Award , \$36,000/yr	<i>University of Florida</i>
2019 - 2020	Undergraduate Research Opportunities Program Award , \$4,000	<i>University of Minnesota</i>

Services and Professional Activities

Mentoring

2022 - 2025	Leyna Huynh , Published article in Journal of Undergraduate Research	<i>University of Florida</i>
2022 - 2025	Gaby Smith , Published article in Journal of Undergraduate Research	<i>University of Florida</i>
2024 - 2025	Lucas John , Nutrition Module Project	<i>University of Florida</i>
2024 - 2025	Abbhinav Sriram , Build-a-Being Yourself Project	<i>University of Florida</i>
2022 - 2024	Tarun Desari , Presentation at Undergraduate Research Symposium	<i>University of Florida</i>
2022 - 2023	Zhuoming Han , Co-authored "A Sense of Urgency:..."	<i>University of Florida</i>

Student Volunteering

2024	Paper Session , International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
2024	DEIA Accessibility Streaming , Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces	<i>IEEE VR</i>
2019	Paper Session , Symposium on Spatial User Interaction	<i>ACM SUI</i>

Reviewing

2024	Conference Reviewer , International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>
2023	Journal Reviewer , International Journal of Human – Computer Studies	<i>IJHCS</i>
2022	Conference Reviewer , Conference on Virtual Reality and 3D User Interfaces	<i>IEEE VR</i>
2022	Conference Reviewer , International Symposium on Mixed and Augmented Reality	<i>IEEE ISMAR</i>